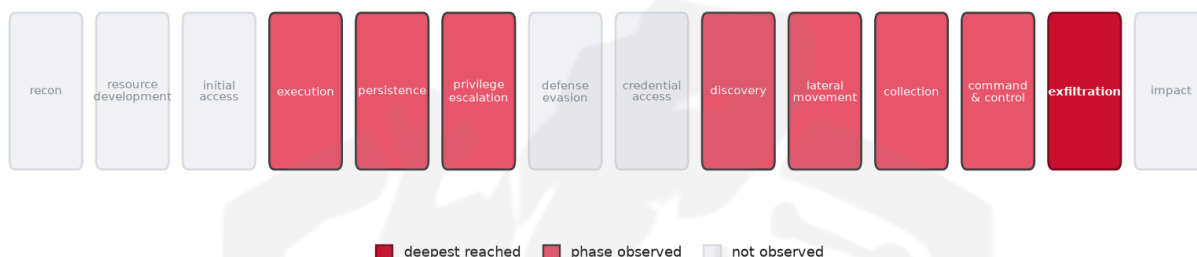


THREAT REPORT: TOY GHOULS DEPLOY MULTIPLE RANSOMWARE FAMILIES

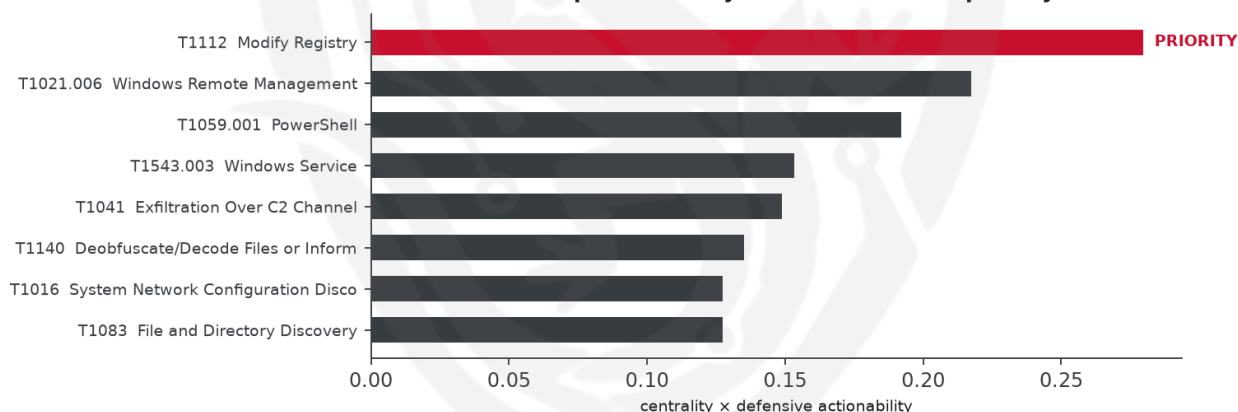
Visual Summary

Kill-Chain Reach — Critical (deepest phase reached: exfiltration)



How far down the attack chain this campaign reached; deepest phase in crimson.

Defensive Chokepoint — why this control is the priority



The control that most disrupts the attack (priority in crimson).

Summary

The threat actor known as Toy Ghoul is observed operating a suite of ransomware and related malware families, including mqtt-bird-agent, matrix-bird-agent, GenieLocker, Babuk-S0638, Babyk, Vasa Locker, and LockBit. No specific CVE or victim geography has been identified in the source material. The activity spans extensive system discovery, credential handling, and data exfiltration techniques. Priority should be given to monitoring sensitive registry keys for modification and restricting registry-edit tools for unprivileged users.

Threat Overview

Toy Ghoul leverages a broad set of malware families—mqtt-bird-agent, matrix-bird-agent, GenieLocker, Babuk-S0638, Babyk, Vasa Locker, and LockBit—to conduct operations. The source does not cite a

particular vulnerability (CVE) exploited, and victim details such as country or sector are not provided.

Attack Chain and Priority Control

The observed activity follows a typical ransomware workflow: initial system and user discovery (T1033, T1082, T1083, T1016, T1057), collection of local data (T1005), credential and configuration harvesting (T1112, T1021.006, T1543.003), use of obfuscation and encryption (T1027, T1573.001, T1140), command-and-control via web protocols and PowerShell (T1071.001, T1059.001, T1059.003), and finally exfiltration over the C2 channel (T1041).

Priority technique: T1112 Modify Registry

Priority control: Monitor sensitive registry keys for modification; restrict registry-edit tools for unprivileged users.

Infrastructure and Corroboration

The enrichment data did not identify any hosting providers or ASNs associated with the malicious infrastructure. AbuseIPDB reported no indicators with high confidence ($\geq 80\%$). No malware families were corroborated by abuse.ch.

Technical Appendix

Ground-truth telemetry from the source pulse; analytical scores are secondary and clearly labelled.

Observed Techniques (ATT&CK, expert-tagged by source)

- T1033 System Owner/User Discovery
- T1573.001 Symmetric Cryptography
- T1543.003 Windows Service
- T1082 System Information Discovery
- T1005 Data from Local System
- T1140 Deobfuscate/Decode Files or Information
- T1112 Modify Registry
- T1021.006 Windows Remote Management
- T1016 System Network Configuration Discovery
- T1083 File and Directory Discovery
- T1049 System Network Connections Discovery
- T1057 Process Discovery
- T1041 Exfiltration Over C2 Channel
- T1059.001 PowerShell
- T1562.001 Impair Defenses: Disable or Modify Tools
- T1027 Obfuscated Files or Information
- T1059.003 Windows Command Shell
- T1071.001 Web Protocols

Analytical Scores

- Priority technique (graph chokepoint): T1112 Modify Registry (centrality 0.2943).
- Operational risk: Critical (score 0.968, reaches exfiltration).

Behavioral Signature Cluster

- Method: technique-overlap cosine vs 170 MITRE ATT&CK Groups (top overlap 0.5869; reference threshold $\tau = 0.6$).
- These are behavioural resemblances for defensive playbook cross-referencing, not an identity assessment. Where the source pulse names an actor, that attribution is authoritative; the overlaps below neither confirm nor contest it.

Nearest historical profiles by behavioural overlap (resemblance only):

Historical Profile	Behavioural Overlap
Stealth Falcon	0.5869
Ke3chang	0.4566
APT19	0.4523
Tropic Trooper	0.4274
Inception	0.4022

Enrichment Signal

- Highest AbuseIPDB confidence among IOCs: 0%.

Indicators of Compromise (defanged — non-clickable)

The network and file indicators observed in this activity are listed below for blocklisting:

Type	Indicator
Domain	meet[.]element[.]tw
Hash	bfadbeee63a4f0bf19ec9deb8fa58f58
Hash	7916c33688385525078bee504c90f359

Flame Cell // Adversary Pivot [BETA]

BETA. A hypothetical tabletop projection, anchored to documented ATT&CK behaviour and technique co-occurrence across 170 tracked groups. It is not a prediction; treat it as a war-game prompt and review

before acting. Spot a pivot that looks wrong? norbert@salacti.com

- **Control applied:** T1112 Modify Registry (persistence)
- **Observed here:** T1112 Modify Registry was the only persistence technique observed in this campaign, so the pivot is projected from cross-actor behaviour.
- **Projected pivot:** T1053 Scheduled Task/Job (persistence)
- **Basis:** of the 19+ groups that use Modify Registry, this pairing runs 1.9x above base rate, a disproportionately-coupled move rather than the obvious one.

With T1112 Modify Registry blocked, Toy Ghouls could preserve the same objective by pivoting to T1053 Scheduled Task/Job, a technique disproportionately paired with it across tracked groups. Defensive countermeasure: Alert on new scheduled tasks (Event ID 4698); restrict schtasks/at to admins; baseline legitimate task creators.

Also plausible (same tactic): T1547 Boot or Logon Autostart Execution (n=17, lift 1.7), T1505 Server Software Component (n=11, lift 2.0)

Detection and hardening for the pivot (T1053 Scheduled Task/Job)

- **Telemetry:** Windows Security (Object Access audit); Microsoft-Windows-TaskScheduler/Operational; Sysmon
- **Detect:**
 - Security 4698 (task created), 4702 (updated), 4700/4701 (enabled/disabled), 4699 (deleted)
 - TaskScheduler/Operational 106 (registered), 140 (updated), 141 (deleted)
 - Sysmon 1 for schtasks.exe and at.exe; Sysmon 11 for writes under C:\Windows\System32\Tasks\
- **Harden:**
 - Restrict schtasks/at to administrators; disable the legacy at.exe
 - Baseline the legitimate task creators and alert on anything outside it
- **MITRE:** M1047 Audit, M1028 Operating System Configuration, M1026 Privileged Account Management · DS0003 Scheduled Job, DS0009 Process, DS0022 File